deposits that are constantly washed down by the three great river systems, extending from the Arabian Sea to the Bay of Bengal.

However, let us confine ourselves to that part of the Himalayan region that protects the subcontinent from the north. Though it was possible for traders and small groups of men to penetrate the Himalayan fortress along the established trade routes, any invading force a la Mahmud of Ghazni in the tenth century, or Tamerlane in the fourteenth century never penetrated the high mountain passes. Hence, in the east, the access to the subcontinent was never across the northern barrier, but followed a gradual and non-violent migration across the Naga Patkai and Naga Hills by races like the Ahom who came into the unoccupied Assam Valley sometime in the mid-twelfth century. The aggressive invasions from the Burmese side were localized and rarely progressed west of the Imphal Valley.

The relationship of the peoples occupying the mountain valleys and hillsides on the southern side of the Himalayan watershed has always been cordial if somewhat aloof. The Bhutia invariably occupied the extreme heights and acted as a buffer between the two regions. The Tibetan plateau was a high altitude desert devoid of rich grazing pastures and arable land, both of which were abundant on the Indian side. Between ad 750 and 850, Tibetan historians claim that their kingdom extended into parts of northern India. Though there is little evidence to buttress this claim, Chinese records suggest that during that period Tibet was militarily quite strong and not too hesitant to advance against Indian Himalayan kingdoms and the Chinese. In ad 787, to stop Tibetan expansion, the Chinese king is said to have entered into an alliance not just with the Indians, but also the Caliph of Baghdad.

Military adventurism against the subcontinent, at the best of times a logistical nightmare, became even less likely from the north with the flow of Buddhism into Tibet. The more primitive Bon (also spelt Phon, traces of which exist in Sikkim even today) form of Buddhism was the national religion of Tibet until the arrival of Padmasambhava (Guru Rinpoche) who immediately got the attention of the people by defeating Chinese ‘demons’. With Padmasambhava in the eighth century came Tantrism in the form of Lamaism and Kamalashila, a philosopher from Nalanda, became the head of the metaphysical branch of the Tibetan church.

Buddhism was, at the same time, playing a major role in ancient India’s relationship with China. In the sixth and seventh centuries, many Buddhist monks from India made the arduous journey to China—either over the land